

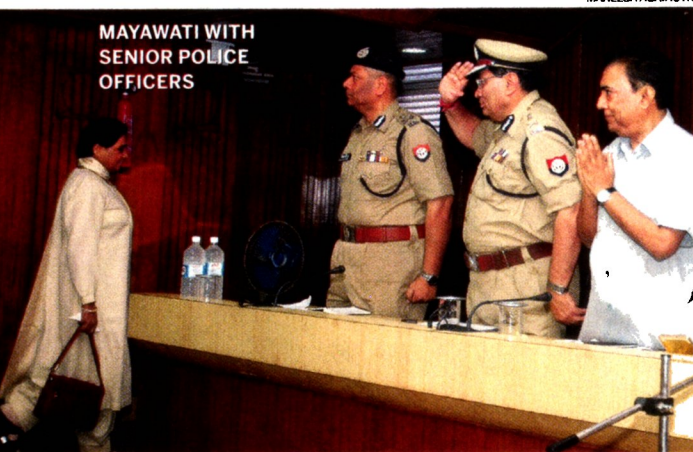
LUCKNOW | Back to Basics

Abandoned by Brahmins in the general elections, Mayawati is back to wooing her core constituency, the Dalits. The chief minister has directed Director-General of Police (DGP) Vikram Singh to treat crimes against Dalits as priority cases. So Singh now flies personally to

the crime scene in a helicopter, gets the crime registered and hands over wads of currency to the Dalit victims. As a result, district police chiefs have been forced to rewrite the police manual for routine investigative protocol. Sealing off the crime scene is no longer on top of their

list. "As soon as we hear about a crime against an SC, we dispatch a team to make a helipad for the DGP instead of investigating the crime," says an SSP. The police department is in another quandary because it is their department which is compensating the victims in cash even though that is the job of the Social Welfare Department. But it is unlikely the state police are about to argue with their formidable chief minister over the issue.

by Subhash Mishra



Solo Run

The Uttar Pradesh Congress is planning to contest all the Assembly seats in the coming bypolls, hoping to cash in on the anti-Mayawati wave as well as any embarrassing fallouts of the Liberhan Commission Report for the BJP and SP.

PATNA | Meaty Role

After losing the Railway Ministry, Lalu Prasad Yadav seems to have abandoned the gods. Or at least the vegetarian ones. A devout vegetarian till recently, Lalu decided to cross over, and his first non-vegetarian meal was fish. (Inspired perchance by Mamata Banerjee's latest introduction to the railways cuisine, the humble fish curry?). The NDA chief didn't limit his choices declaring, "I started with fish and ended up with chicken". Lalu had turned famously vegetarian after an encounter with none other than Lord Shiva in his dreams during his 2001 judicial custody in connection with the fodder scam. This instruction from Lord Shiva had proved very lucky for the Bihar strongman who had remained in power until the last Lok Sabha polls. Now, out of favour in Delhi, Lalu decided to please his palate instead, so he says he simply apologised to Lord Shiva and other relevant gods and goddesses before tucking into some *maach*.

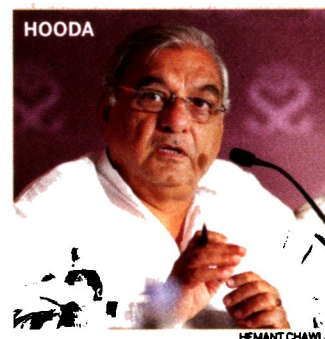
by Amitabh Srivastava



AFTER NINE YEARS OF ABSTINENCE, LALU HAS TAKEN TO EATING MEAT

DELHI | Catch-22

The Congress is divided over whether to bring forward the Haryana Assembly polls to club them with two state polls slated for October. The Haryana Assembly's term expires on March 20 while Maharashtra and Arunachal Pradesh go to the polls in three months. The Congress is in power in Haryana led by Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda. Some Congressmen believe that the party should ride the Lok Sabha wave (it won nine of the 10 seats) and prepone the



polls before the feel-good wears off. But the state leaders disagree saying Assembly and general elections cannot be equated. The latter view may prevail because many remember the Vajpayee government's failed 2004 experiment. The NDA brought forward the Lok Sabha polls based on a favourable Assembly verdict and the rest turned out to be their sorry history.

by Priya Sahgal